

THE DORMITION OF THE THEOTOKOS: SHE DID NOT DIE LIKE OTHERS DIE

SESSION 00.15 HANDOUT

This is the last handout of Topic 00. You have walked fifteen weeks. You have arrived.

NAME _____ DATE _____

♦ MEMORY VERSE — COPY BY HAND

Christ spoke these words from the Cross to His Mother and to His beloved disciple John. The Orthodox Church has always understood that He was speaking to every Christian. She is your Mother now. Copy the verse below twice in your best handwriting.

When Jesus saw His mother, and the disciple whom He loved standing by, He said to His mother, "Woman, behold thy son!" Then He said to the disciple, "Behold thy mother!" And from that hour the disciple took her to his own home. — John 19:26–27

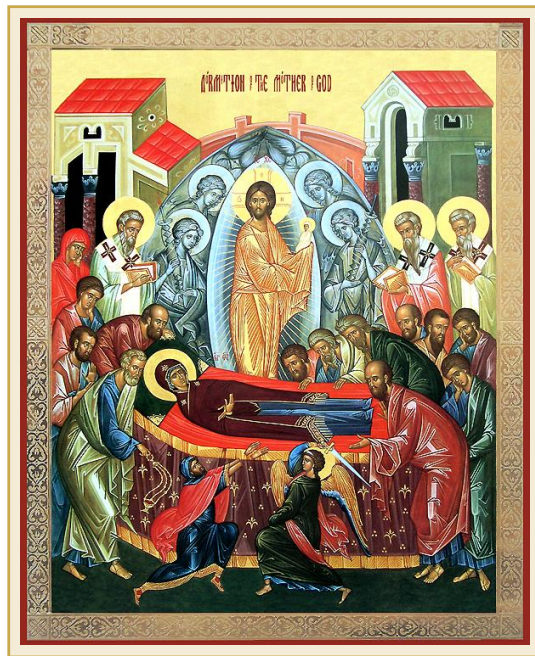
♦ VOCABULARY — MATCH EACH WORD TO ITS MEANING

Draw a line from each word on the left to its meaning on the right.

DORMITION	•	• The almond-shape of golden or blue light around Christ in many Orthodox icons. The icon's way of showing divine glory.
BIER	•	• Greek for <i>falling asleep</i> — the Orthodox name for the Theotokos's death. She fell asleep, and her Son came down to carry her home.
MANDORLA	•	• The first to enter what is promised to everyone united to Christ — bodies raised, glorified, taken to be with Him forever. The Theotokos has <i>gone ahead of us</i> into it.
FIRST-FRUITS	•	• A small low table or bed on which a body is laid for burial. The Dormition icon shows the Theotokos lying on one, surrounded by the weeping Apostles.

♦ LAYOUT — LABEL THE DORMITION ICON

Look at the Dormition icon — the one displayed at SJTD this week, or printed for you alongside this handout, or shown to you on a screen. Find the five parts below. Draw a small arrow from each label to where it appears in the icon.



The Dormition of the Theotokos · use this icon for the labeling exercise below

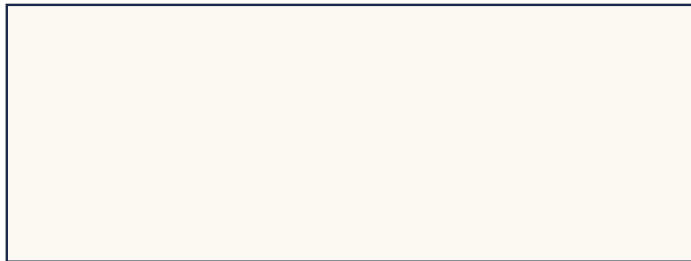
- ☐ **The bier** — the low table where the Theotokos lies as if asleep
- ☐ **The Theotokos** — eyes closed, hands folded, at peace
- ☐ **The twelve Apostles** — gathered around her, weeping, leaning on each other
- ☐ **Christ** — standing behind the bier, surrounded by the **mandorla** (almond-shape of light)
- ☐ **The swaddled infant** — held in Christ's arms. *That infant is her soul.* In life, she held Him as a baby; in death, He holds her.

♦ SKETCH — IN LIFE, SHE HELD HIM; IN DEATH, HE HOLDS HER

In the boxes below, draw the two halves of the great image at the heart of the Dormition icon. The Mother of God icon (left) and the Dormition icon (right) belong together. They are the two ends of the same love.

IN LIFE — THE MOTHER OF GOD

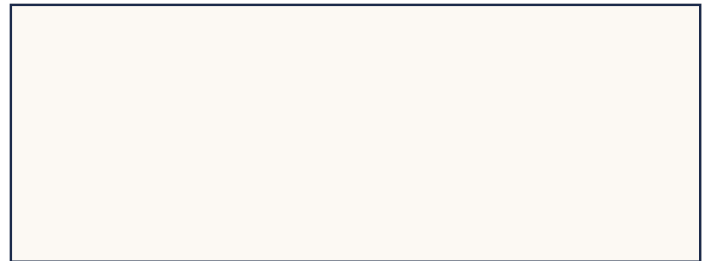
She holds the infant Christ



The Theotokos with the infant Christ on her chest, blessing.

IN DEATH — THE DORMITION

Christ holds the swaddled infant — her



Christ with the swaddled-infant soul of His Mother in His arms.

♦ REFLECTION — WRITE 5 TO 7 SENTENCES (THIS ONE IS LONGER — IT IS THE CLOSE OF TOPIC 00)

Fifteen weeks ago, you opened *The Church That Stayed*. Look back at what you have walked through: the trunk-and-branch tree, the Sign of the Cross, icons, the Theotokos, your Chrismation, your first Communion, the Divine Liturgy, the Apostles' Fast, Peter and Paul, your prayer corner, your patron St. Herman, the Prophet Elias, the Dormition Fast, and now her great feast. **You have arrived.**

Write 5 to 7 sentences. How are you different now from who you were on May 18? What has changed? What was the hardest part? What was the most beautiful part? What do you carry with you into Year 1? *Take real time with this one. There is no wrong answer. It's okay if your answer is just a list. It's okay if some of it is hard to put into words.*

MOST HOLY THEOTOKOS, SAVE US.